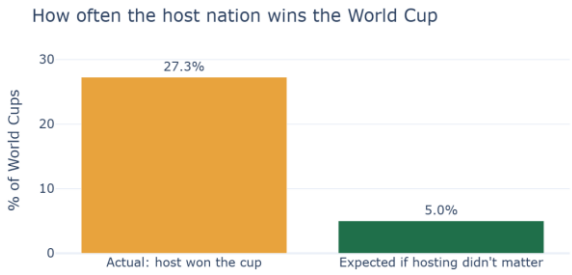
FIFA World Cup 2026: Executive Summary

Three findings from 92 years of World Cup history (1930-2022) and what we recommend for 2026.

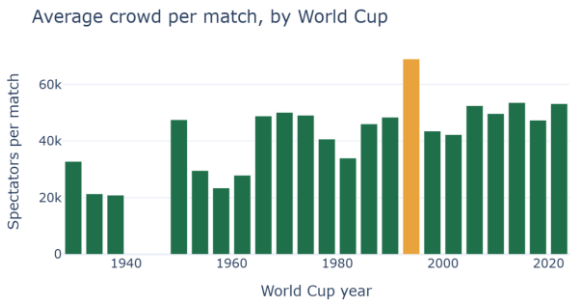
1. Host nations win far more often than chance predicts



Hosts won 6 of the 22 World Cups (27%), against about 5% if hosting made no difference. A binomial test gives $p \approx 0.0006$, so this is very unlikely to be luck.

Recommendation: Based on this, we recommend treating the USA, Mexico and Canada as stronger contenders than their FIFA rankings suggest, securing sponsor visibility with the host teams, and planning extra capacity for the late-round matches in host cities.

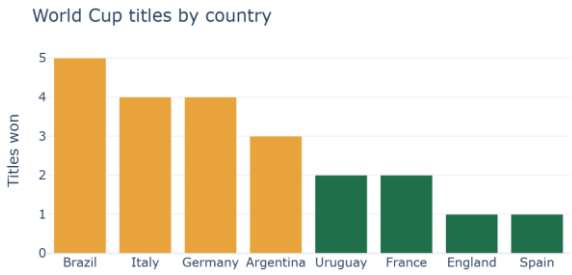
2. Crowds peaked in the USA in 1994, and the USA hosts most of 2026



The 1994 World Cup averaged about 69,000 spectators per match, the highest ever. Recent tournaments average roughly 50,000-54,000. In 2026, 80 of the 104 matches are in the USA.

Recommendation: Based on this, we recommend using 1994 (about 69,000 per match) as the planning benchmark for US venues and concentrating staffing, ticketing and hospitality resources in the USA.

3. Four countries hold 73% of all titles



Only 8 countries have won the World Cup, and Brazil, Italy, Germany and Argentina hold 16 of the 22 titles. The last four winners (Spain, Germany, France, Argentina) were all different, however.

Recommendation: Based on this, we recommend anchoring sponsorship around the traditional powers' fan markets, while reserving part of the budget for other contenders such as Spain and France.